

Lūdente linguā
Language Use and Performance in Zoological Nomenclature

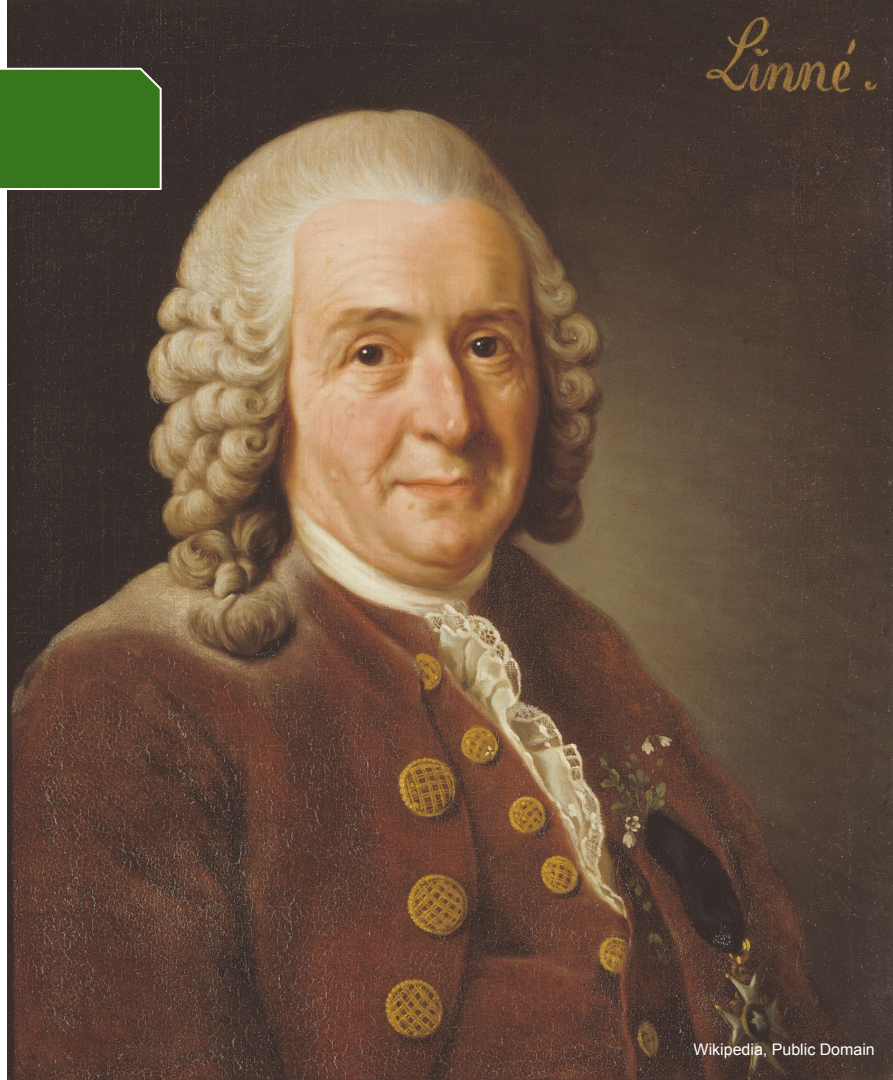
Richard Littauer - http://richard.social

Rimu https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/198921399

Linnaeus

- Swedish
- 1707-1778
- The "father of modern taxonomy"
- Published *Systema Naturæ* in 1738

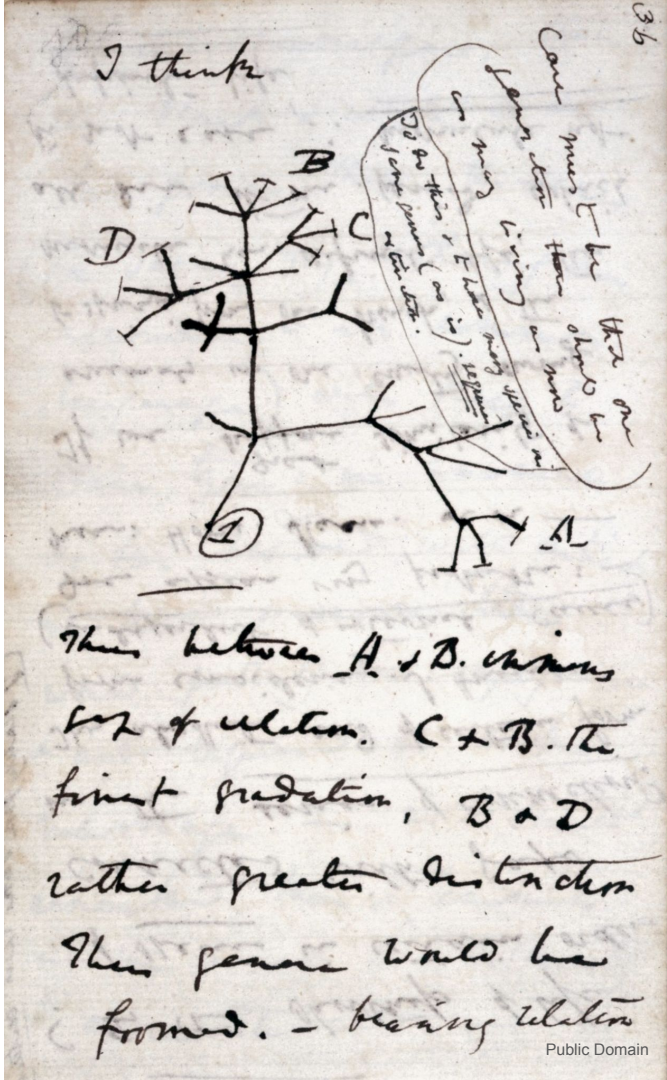
"Linnaeus was in reality a poet who happened to become a naturalist."
~ Strindberg



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Taxonomy

- Figuring out how life is related
- Naming those life forms.



Taxonomy

➤ ***Porphyrio hochstetteri*** (A.B. Meyer)

South Island Takahe |Takahē

Notornis Mantellii Ellman, 1861: *Zoologist 19*: 7470 – New Zealand. Junior primary homonym of *Notornis mantelli* Owen, 1848.

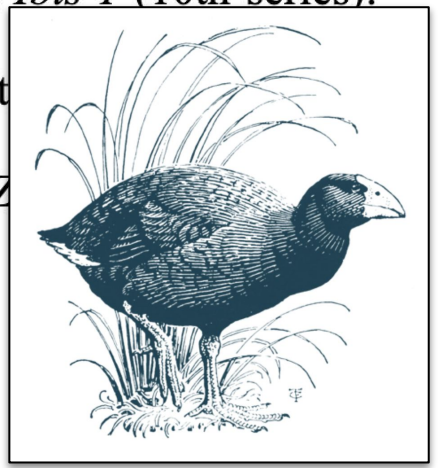
Notornis hochstetteri A.B. Meyer, 1883: *Abbildungen von Voegel-Skeletten 1*(4–5): 28, pls 34–37 – North of Mararoa R., 3.5 miles east Whitestone R. and 9 miles south-east of south end of Lake Te Anau, Fiordland.

Notornis parkeri Forbes, 1892: *Trans. N.Z. Inst. 24*: 187 – Half a mile east of Patience Bay, Lake Te Anau, Fiordland.

Mantellornis hochstetteri (A.B. Meyer); Mathews & Iredale 1913, *Ibis 1* (10th series): 216.

Porphyrio mantelli hochstetteri (A.B. Meyer); Checklist Commit
Birds N.Z.: 125.

Porphyrio hochstetteri (A.B. Meyer); Holdaway *et al.* 2001, *New Z*
28(2): 132, 178.



https://www.birdsnz.org.nz/society-publications/checklist/

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INTERNATIONAL CODE OF ZOOLOGICAL NOMENCLATURE

Fourth Edition

[Incorporating **A.** Declaration 45, Addition of Recommendations to Article 73 and of the term "specimen, preserved" to the Glossary, **B.** Declaration 44, amendments of Article 74.7.3, with effect from 31 December 1999, and **C.** the Amendment on e-publication, amendments to Articles 8, 9, 10, 21 and 78, with effect from 1 January 2012]

adopted by the
International Union of Biological Sciences

The provisions of this Code supersede those of the previous editions with effect from 1 January 2000



ISBN 0 85301 006 4

The author of this Code is the International Commission on Zoological Nomenclature

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INTERNATIONAL COD...

Fourth Edition

[Incorporating **A.** Declaration 45, Addition of ... 44, amendments of Article 74.7.3, with effect... 21 and 78, with effect from 1 January 2012]

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The provisions of this Code supersede those ...

ICZN

ISBN 0 85301 006 4

The author of this Code is the International Commission on Zoological Nomenclature

"The Code":

- French and English
- 90 Articles
- Glossary
- Examples (which don't count)

CAROLI LINNÆI

EQUITIS DE STELLA POLARI,

ARCHIATRI REGII, MED. & BOTAN. PROFESS. UPSAL.;
ACAD. UPSAL. HOLMENS. PETROPOL. BEROL. IMPER.
LOND. MONSPEL. TOLOS. FLORENT. SOC.

SYSTEMA NATURÆ

PER

REGNA TRIA NATURÆ,

SECUNDUM

CLASSES, ORDINES,
GENERA, SPECIES,

CUM

CHARACTERIBUS, DIFFERENTIIS,
SYNONYMIS, LOCIS.

TOMUS I.

EDITIO DECIMA, REFORMATA.

Cum Privilegio S:æ R:æ M:tis Sveciæ.

HOLMIÆ,

IMPENSIS DIRECT. LAURENTII SALVII,
1758.

Article 3: The beginning

- Starts with Linnaeus 1758, on Jan. 1.
- Simultaneously the beginning of the use of the Code, and also of the first valid names



Linnaeus https://www.biodiversitylibrary.org/page/727037#page/3/mode/1up
Gessner: https://archive.org/details/gri_33125010867691/page/214/mode/2up?q=Arquata

Article 8.2 Disclamation

"A work that contains a statement to the effect that it is not issued for public and permanent scientific record, or for purposes of zoological nomenclature, is not published within the meaning of the Code."

This presentation is so stated.



© Jacqui Geux https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/28103314

Article 11.2 Latin alphabet

Haematopus unicolor

And not:

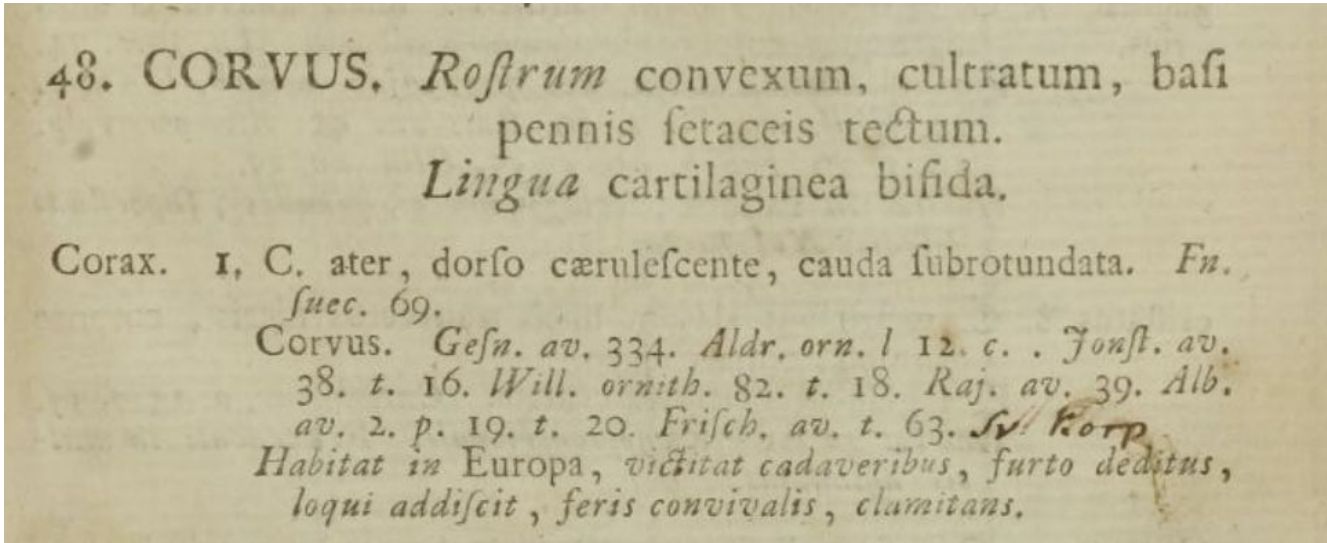


© Sebastian Doak https://www.inaturalist.org/photos/107051293

Article 11.3 Derivation

Names don't have to be Latin names.

Cf. *Manu antiquus* Marples, 1946, or *Corvus corax* Linnaeus, 1738

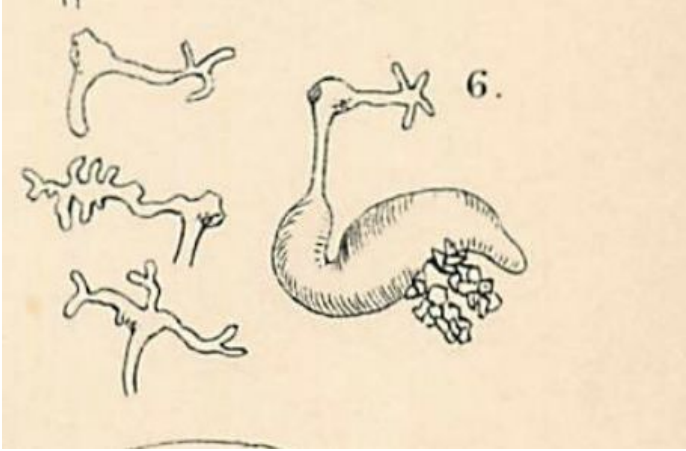


48. CORVUS. *Roſtrum* convexum, cultratum, baſi pennis ſetaceis tectum.
Lingua cartilaginea bifida.

Corax. 1. C. ater, dorſo cæruleſcente, cauda ſubrotundata. *Fn. ſuec.* 69.
Corvus. *Geſn. av.* 334. *Aldr. orn. l* 12. *c.* . *Jonſt. av.* 38. *t.* 16. *Will. ornith.* 82. *t.* 18. *Raj. av.* 39. *Alb. av.* 2. *p.* 19. *t.* 20. *Friſch. av. t.* 63. Sv. Korp
Habitat in Europa, *victitat cadaveribus, furto deditus, loqui addiſcit, feris convivalis, clamitans.*

Systema Naturæ https://www.biodiversitylibrary.org/page/727037

Article 11.9 Species names



Can be:

- an adjective in the nominative singular
- a noun in the nominative singular
- a noun in the genitive case, or:

"11.9.1.4. an adjective used as a substantive in the genitive case and derived from the specific name of an organism with which the animal in question is associated (as in *Lernaeocera lusci*, a copepod parasitic on *Trisopterus luscus*)."

Bassett-Smith, P.W. (1896). Notes on the parasitic Copepoda of fish obtained at Plymouth, with descriptions of new species. Annals and Magazine of Natural History (6)18:8-16, pls. 3-6. (vii-1896)
https://www.marinespecies.org/aphia.php?p=sourcedetails&id=71842

Article 23 Principle of priority

First means first.



Gould, public domain

- †***Heteralocha acutirostris*** (Gould) **Huia**

  Neomorpha acutirostris Gould, 1837: *Synop. Birds Australia 1*: pl. 11 & text – North Island.

  Neomorpha crassirostris Gould, 1837: *Synop. Birds Australia 1*: pl. 11 & text – North Island.

  Neomorpha Gouldii G.R. Gray, 1841: *List Gen. Birds* (2nd edition): 15. Unnecessary *nomen novum* for *Neomorpha acutirostris* Gould, 1837.

  Heteralocha Gouldi (G.R. Gray); Cabanis 1851, *Mus. Heineanum 1*: 218. Unjustified emendation.

  Heteralocha gouldi (G.R. Gray); G.R. Gray 1862, *Ibis 4*: 217. Unjustified emendation.

  Heteralocha acutirostris (Gould); Buller 1872 (Apr.), *History of the Birds of N.Z.*, 1st edition (part 1): 63.

  Heteralocha auctirostris (Gould); Enys 1876, *Trans. Proc. N.Z. Inst. 8*: 204. Misspelling.

Article 24 First Reviser

- Many names – Bruce & McAllan (1990)
- *Calidris melanotos* v. *maculata* Vieillot, 1819 – Wetmore

By me:

- *Larus dominicanus antipodum* v. *antipodus* Bruch, 1853
- *Branta* v. *Brandae* Scopoli, 1769
- *Mohoua, Mohouas, Mohoua-houa* Lesson, 183x?

LES MOHOUAS (2).

Ils tiennent des picucules, des grimpereaux et des gobe-mouches. Leur bec est gros, pointu, courbé, à peine infléchi à sa pointe, qui est légèrement arrondie, et pourvue d'une très petite dentelure. Les narines sont ouvertes et médianes; la mandibule supérieure est carénée, et l'inférieure est rectiligne. La commissure du bec est garnie de soies roides et longues. La langue est ciliée. Les ailes s'allongent jusqu'au milieu de la queue. Celle-ci a douze pennes fortes, étagées, et usées à leur sommet. Les tarses sont très forts.

La seule espèce de ce groupe a été découverte sur les bords de la baie Tasman, où les naturels lui donnent le nom de *mohoua-houa* : c'est le *grimpereau hétéroclite* (3) à dos olivâtre, à ailes brunâtres frangées de jaunâtre, et tête, poitrine et ventre jaunes. Son gésier ne renfermoit que des baies.



(1) *Sclerurus*, ibid.

(2) *Mohoua*, Less.

(3) *Certhia heteroclites*

fig. 1, p. 223

Lesson 1837 (?): Oeuvres completes de Buffon, 9 p. 139

Article 26. Assumption of Greek or Latin



Badly transliterated:

- Athene, Gerygone, Eudynamys, Aegotheles, Gymnorhina

Latin or Greek?

- Ptilinopus, Hirundapus, Apus, Haematopus, Phalaropus, Lagopus

© Christoph Moning https://www.inaturalist.org/observations/113797579

Article 30.1 Gender of genus-group names

If Latin, Latin.

If Greek, Greek.

If Greek but looks like Latin, like Latin.

If disclaimed, not Greek or Latin.

If “common or variable”, masculine.

If ends in -*ops*, masculine.



Article 30.2 Gender of genus-group names

If in “modern European language”,

the gender of that word.

Else, as noted by author.

Or by combination.

Or masculine,

unless ends in -*a* (feminine.);

-*um*, -*on*, or -*u* (neuter).



Article 31.2 Agreement

Species must agree with genus.

31.2.1: Compound names ≠ agree.

31.2.2: If either N or Adj:

- Did the author note it?
- Is usage decisive?
- Can it be regarded as either?



Article 31.2 Agreement

But it really depends.

Compound nouns: 11 species.

Substantives: 11 species.

Unclear N+Adj: 10 species.

Medieval Latin: 6 species.

Errors in Code examples: 2.

Unresolvable: ???



Local birds with confusing names

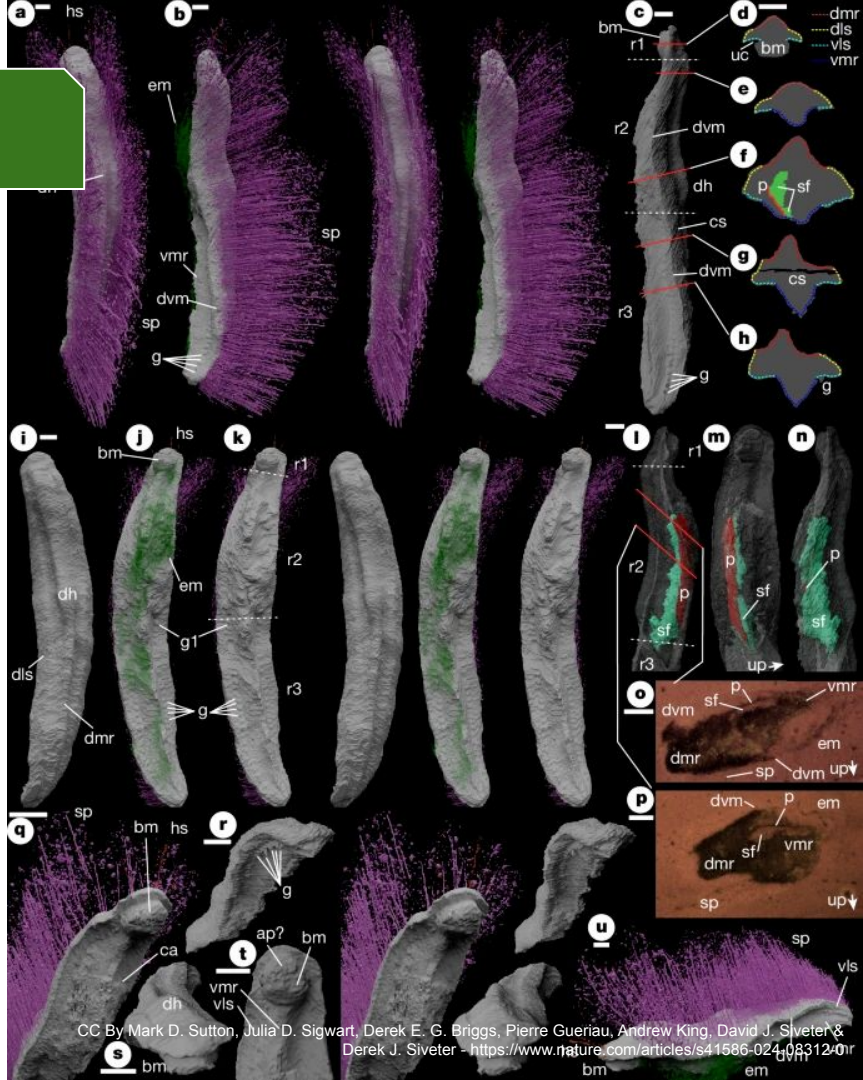
Megalapteryx didinus, Euryapteryx curtus, Euryapteryx curtus curtus, Dendrocygna, Cygnus atratus, Cygnus sumnerensis chathamicus, Branta, Numida, Callipepla, Callipepla californica, Synoicus, Ptilinopus, Eudynamys, Aegotheles, Hirundapus, Hirundapus caudacutus, Hirundapus caudacutus caudacutus, Apus, Apus pacificus, Apus pacificus pacificus, Zapornia pusilla, Tribonyx hodgenorum, Haematopus, Pluvialis dominicus, Numenius hudsonicus, Arenaria, Calidris, Calidris acuminata, Calidris ferruginea, Calidris alpina, Calidris melanotos, Calidris pusilla, Phalaropus, Phalaropus fulicarius, Phalaropus lobatus, Anous albivittus, Gygis alba, Larus dominicanus dominicanus antipodum, Onychoprion fuscatus serratus, Onychoprion anaethetus melanopterus, Chlidonias leucopterus, Chlidonias hybridus, Chlidonias hybridus javanicus, Aptenodytes patagonicus, Pygoscelis papua taeniata, Diomedea, Diomedea antipodensis, Diomedea antipodensis antipodensis, Thalassarche, Thalassarche impavida, Hydrobates leucorhous, Thalassoica, Daption capense, Ardenna pacifica chlororhyncha, Pelecanoides georgicus, Pelecanoides georgicus georgicus, Morus, Sula leucogaster plotus, Bubulcus ibis coromandus, Ardea intermedia plumifera, Botaurus poiciloptilus, Aquila, Tyto alba delicatula, Athene, Eurystomus orientalis pacificus, Todiramphus, Todiramphus sanctus, Cacatua galerita, Platycercus eximius, Cyanoramphus, Cyanoramphus novaezelandiae chathamensis, Anthornis, Anthornis melanura obscura, Anthochaera carunculata, Gerygone, Gerygone albofrontata, Mohoua, Artamus cyanopterus, Gymnorhina, Petroica, Petroica macrocephala, Petroica macrocephala macrocephala, Poodytes punctatus stewartianus, Passer domesticus, Acanthis, Acanthis flammea, Anas, Oreortyx, Coturnix coromandelica, Lophura nycthemera, Lagopus, Lagopus lagopus scotica, Pluvialis apricaria, Passer montanus, Alectoris rufa

Ok, so the Code is bad. So what?

- The problem isn't just ambiguity in the Code.
- It's how that Code is applied.

The problem with names

- Eponyms
  - *Rhynchophanes mccownii, Pterodroma cookii*
- Misspellings in original definitions
  - *Chelaner burchera, A. lopdelli*
- Names with no historical basis
  - *Athene*, *Calidris canutus*
- Confusing names
  - *Calidris melanotos*
- Silly names.
  - *Daption capense*
  - *Punk* and *Emo*



CC By Mark D. Sutton, Julia D. Sigwart, Derek E. G. Briggs, Pierre Gueriau, Andrew King, David J. Siveter & Derek J. Siveter - https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-024-08312-0



FIGURE 8. Mendol, a traditional food typically from Malang area, East Java, Indonesia. A. served on its own without other food. B. Served as a complementary side dish. Photographs by Richo Firmansyah.

Gender agreement

- What's a dictionary?
- Generally, masculine and feminine are marked - and neuter is unmarked. Neuter is the default.
- Names ending in -*a* aren't all feminine.
- Substantives

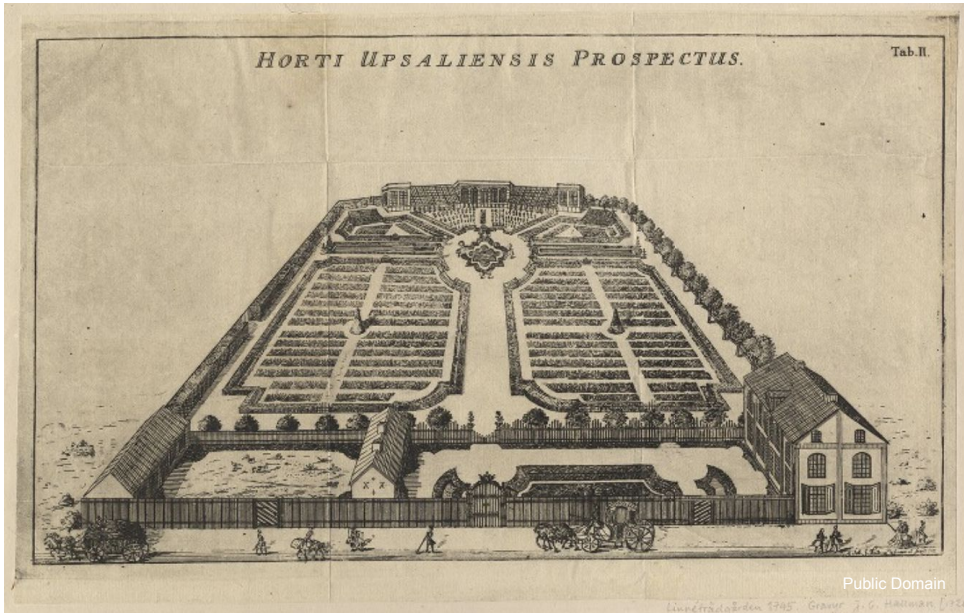


CC-BY-SA Ad Meskens Wikipedia

Passer domestica



- In Medieval Latin means "housemaid"
- Probably not the intended meaning.
- But Linnaeus had 81 housemaids at his home in Uppsala (Pónten 2020)
- According to Art. 31.2, *could* be the meaning, so should be.
- But it isn't.



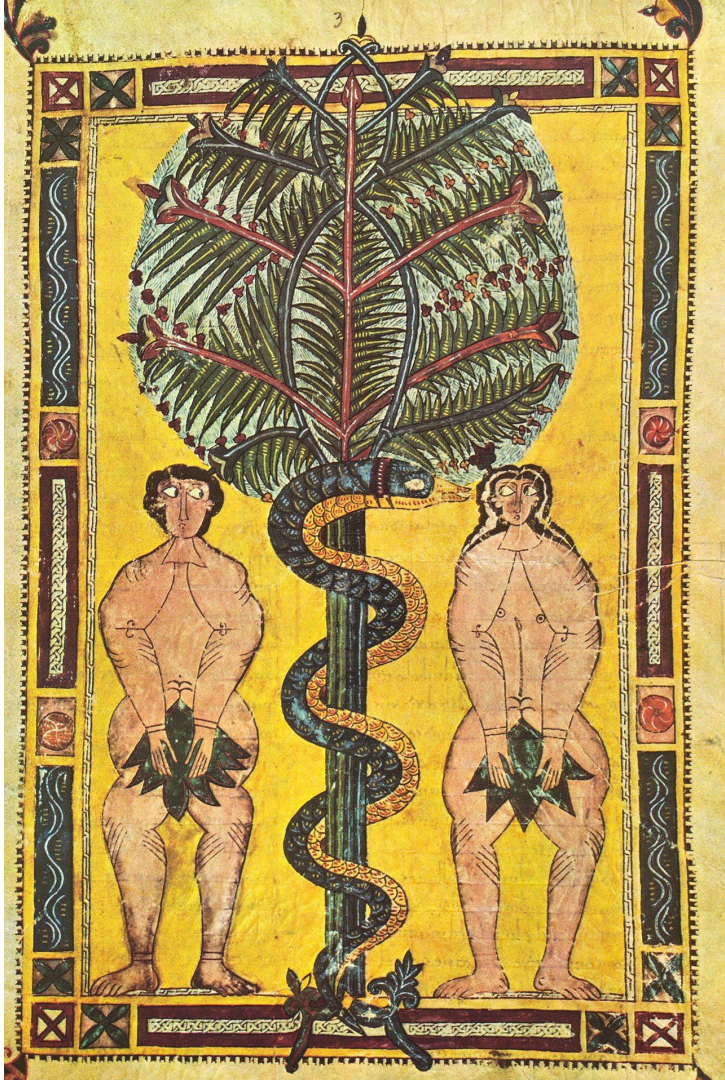
Ok, again, so what?

- The Code exists to standardize naming.
- The methods are not impartial, clear, or reproducible.
- The result is confusion and politics.
- This sidelines voices:
  - Non-Anglo or Francophones
  - Indigenous
  - Women
  - Trans and takatāpui.

Thanks.

- Questions?

http://richard.social



Adam and Eve Expulsion c. 950, Public Domain